

How frequently do you work with first-time home buyers?

An agent who has experience with first-time home buyers may be more aware of special incentives, credits, and programs that can save you money. This will also be the biggest purchase you have made to date, and you'll need someone who will listen to your concerns, answer all your questions, and not make you feel stupid for asking them—even if your questions *are* slightly stupid. (We've all been there, and we even dedicated an entire section to these kinds of questions in the final chapter.)

How many closings do you handle per year? How long have you been licensed?

While an agent who is not very busy can sometimes be a good choice because they might give you extra attention as their primary client, an experienced agent will be able to handle the many problems that can pop up during the inspection and closing process. When you do find a deal that meets your criteria, you want to eliminate mistakes in the closing process and ensure it runs smoothly.

If you decide to work with a less experienced agent, ask who they work with as a mentor and whether they will have professional help to guide you through the closing process. You don't want clerical errors to cause problems down the line. A professional—even a less-experienced one—should readily acknowledge any gap in their experience and be prepared to turn to a mentor if any difficulties arise.

You can also gauge an agent's experience by sharing your market research and asking them for their opinion. If they are unable to provide the detailed insight that you were able to uncover from driving neighborhoods and digging up recent sales, they might not be in tune with your local market.

After just a few meetings with local investors, homeowners, and agents, you will be able to readily pick up who does and does not know what they're talking about. An agent who is a real pro will show you where you're right and wrong in ways that are clear to you. Be wary of the agent who overwhelms you with numbers and data you can't easily follow. Do not be intimidated by their expertise—instead, insist that they present information to you in a way you can understand.